

Introduction to Group Stages

Objectives:

At the end of this lecture, students should be able to:

1. Identify the characteristics of the stages of groups.
2. Understand some key representations of these characteristics.

The four stages we will be discussion are: Forming, Storming, Norming, and Performing. The two middle stages will be referred to as transition stages at times.

Content	PPT Slide
Introduction: My father is a woodworker. He is skilled beyond my wildest dreams at creating art out of trees. Sometimes I just sit back and marvel at how his hands make what they do. But one skill he has I will never understand is knowing what kind of wood he is working with. How can he know what kind of tree made the wood sitting on shelves stacked one on top of the other? (Slide) He knows by their bark. By their leaves. By the size of the tree and the location where it likes to grow. But he also must know these things when they are in different seasons or stacked at the store. As we start as group leaders the stages may seem unrecognizable. But as we gain experience, they start to stand out to us. Because we do the same thing that my dad does in his shop. We come to know the characteristics of the stages and what they look like in the group and the members of the group and we identify where we are by what we see. I'm going to ask you some questions as we go through this information and I'm not looking for perfect answers, let's just make this a conversation. So, having said this, what are some of the characteristics we should be looking for (some leaves and bark types) as we try and figure out where we are in a group stage? Here they are...	Slide #3 and #4
Content of the discussion: One telltale sign of the stage the group is the question "What are people talking about?" When people are talking about the weather and the game last week, this is a clear sign you are in the beginning stage. When Paul says to Suzie, "I like your shoes, where did you get them?" you can assume you are just beginning the group. Members may also be focused on advice giving in the beginning stages. People like to feel helpful to each other, even when it's not very helpful. People need to get to know one another before they disclose risky struggles, but they also feel	Slide #5

uncomfortable just staring at each other. Although, this is a good place to get to know your members too. The chatty ones and the ones who are comfortable just staring. As the group progresses stages, people will start to disclose, but in the form of basic facts about themselves. Family facts, where they work, how they know the leader/counselor, but nothing of intimate disclosure. Moving forward members will begin to talk about their emotions on a deeper level. They may even disclose a few more intimate facts about their beliefs and why they are in the group. They will start to move from things they tell a waitress at lunch to things they have never told anyone about themselves. When a group is in the working stage the real reason for group work may come out. They may start disclosing past trauma, secrets that they never thought anyone would hear them say, and harm they did to others from long past. Divorces and affairs and all sorts of details start to be disclosed in this stage. They also start making meaning of their story and the emotions they have felt. Meaning making has been compared to the plot in a story. A story void of plot is just facts and characters. But it's not going anywhere, and it doesn't have a moral. Plot tells us where we've been and why, it tells us what the other characters meant to us, and it tells us who we are. The working stage allows members to hear interpersonal dialogue about how others see them as well. Honestly, this working stage and the beginning stage are probably the easiest stage to discern based on content. It's fairly obvious when people are working on their true reason for being in the group and true goals. Hearing these characteristics, and what we've talked about and experienced this week, the stages can be difficult to identify. What makes it so? The tendency to circle back. Stages aren't linear.	
References to time: "What are people talking about?" is a great indicator of stage. And, when paired with, "When did it happen?", the "Where are we?" starts to take shape. When members in the beginning stages of group refer to their narrative over time, they tend to be as illusive and protected as "What" they are talking about. They are not ready to reveal anything more than basic information until they feel safe in the group, and they want to know people have common interests before they "go there". So, they usually keep time as a vague indicator to who they are and why they are there. When Paul says to Suzie (sorry I'm picking on Paul, but he's just not ready yet!) a while back I had a run in with a guy I don't like very much... It's <i>NOT</i> about to get real, but he is seeking for inclusion and safety. He might move the group into a discussion about "what happened when I was a kid" or even further into "what happened when I was 10" as the group moves into the transitional stages. Quick question (not a trick question), when it comes to time, the goal is to work in what frame of time?	Slide #6

The here-and-now. But here, the group is working in the there-and-then. Topics held in the recent past move the group further into the room on the day of rather than somewhere else sometime in the past the group is not familiar with. It's a necessary step to building cohesion in the group, but it's not where the real work is done. The here-and-now of the working stage is a fantastic bit of therapeutic tact and skill. The immediacy of the room and the emotion in the room currently and the palpable responses and reactions are so transformative that this phenomenon alone is responsible for much change in members (and leaders if we will allow it). A here-and-now interpersonal experience is something most group members have never realized and the impact it has on their relationships is profound. Because of this Working in the time frame of here-and-now does not happen by accident. It is something the leader needs to move the group into with process questions like, "When you heard Sally talk about her divorce, what did you wish for her just now?" I could talk about the here-and-now all day because it has been so important in helping clients progress, but it also moves us into our next characteristic.	
Self-Awareness: Let's pause on me talking here for just a second. I want to hear from you about some awareness you have. Neither I nor Dr. Ford want to trigger you to trauma, so, to keep it between a 3 and a 6 on the "how anxious this makes me feel" scale, let's talk about your bucket list. Making and keeping track of a bucket list is a good way to help us find awareness of personal and professional goals we might have. It also helps us become and stay aware of our longings for shared experiences with others. So, now that you've had a second to think about it. 3-4 of you unmute and shout out a bucket list item. Great job. Thanks for that interaction. (Slide #8) It may be difficult for counseling students about to enter practicum and internship to imagine people who are not aware of themselves. But you're about to encounter some of those folks. And seeing people who block or protect is common in the initial stages of the group as well. And why do they do this? Anxiety! They don't hate you as the leader or resist on purpose. They are thinking with their amygdala and are in fight, flight, freeze, or fawn! As the stages progress, the interpersonal nature of the group and the encouragement to interact on a deeper level, help people become aware of thoughts, feelings, and reactions. They can start to be aware in a safe place by trying on language to describe what is going on with and in them (and between them and others) and can start to zone in on thoughts, feelings, and reactions that have been around a long time, just buried or blocked by pain. The ultimate self-awareness is a constant awareness of those aspects of self and an immediate ability to live in a state of meaning-making. This is a lofty and high goal and all of us are certainly working on	Slide #7 & #8

this ability continuously. But catching glimpses of self-awareness in members and giving feedback about growth is important. “Bob, you just brought us in a little closer with that comment. Does anyone feel like they know Bob more now?” So, we can use self-awareness as a way to check out where we are in the group. We can also use emotions.	
Openness to oneself: I heard this week that all of you have been exposed to this emotions or feelings wheel in 505 so this should be a recognizable exercise to you. We are not just in programs like this to learn about other, but ourselves as well. However, getting to know yourself better is not something we are all taught. Sometimes we are taught to hide our emotions and dismiss them as unimportant or even harmful. Many people join a group for as basic of a reason as understanding why they don’t have better relationships. They are unaware of how closed they are to their own story and emotions. Take a look at this emotion wheel and a couple of you unmute and let us all in on what you are experiencing right now. I’ll start, I’m feeling...(Slide #10) At the far end of the spectrum of Openness to oneself would be someone who would look at this wheel and tell you they never think about emotion or they might monologue about what they learned about emotion in an intro to psych class in undergrad. They might even get angry and argue the point of asking such questions. But, as time goes on and the stage of the group moves closer to working or performing, they start to talk less about others in the group or give advice and start to add plot to the story. Member’s willingness to talk about themselves rather than other non-group characters, to name the emotion specifically, or to admit that there may be something to this feelings thing brings the work into the room. In the beginning stage, a closed member might say things like “I don’t know why my ex-wife always told me that talking to me was like talking to a brick wall?” While the other members are trying to figure out how to tell him that it’s because he shows the same expression for mad as he does sad. Members can help each other open up to themselves by patiently allowing them to try on emotions and meaning of their story and see how they fit. This part of a working group is fun to see. When Alice says to Jim, “you used a word last time that I’ve been thinking about ever since. I think I feel caged sometimes too, like a tiger pacing back and forth”, they are in it. Something to remember is, that in the transitional stages, trying on emotions might get contentious or even annoying. People aren’t as willing to work together yet. They are still focused on their own issues. A sign of a later or working stage is that members encourage the others to focus on themselves and talk more explicitly about emotion in the room.	Slide #9 & #10

Feedback from others: This brings us to another characteristic of stages: a leaf for us to detect. Here's a question for a show of hands. How many of you in High School or undergrad would dread or get angry when you read a teacher's comments on a paper or test? I used to get so discouraged when my mom would edit a paper for me (not sure why I thought it would be a good idea, but...). I had to change my mindset from, she's just trying to show me up, to, she's just trying to help. (I don't ask her to edit anymore...) Someone tell me how it feels when you hear criticism. (Slide #12) If group members have the idea that others are out to get them or make them look bad (for one it's good for the leaders to note this and employ it in interpersonal work later) they will tend to see feedback as criticism. They will feel like you guys just mentioned and not much like opening up at first. As groups go, people want to give each other feedback. We've already mentioned that, at first, it is more like advice and shifting out of emotion. But this characteristic is more about how people view that feedback. Is it outright rejected? Is it relegated to the junk drawer of interpersonal relating? (You know, that place you stick all the unsolicited counsel regarding who to marry or where to live. We all have a relational junk drawer!) Do you observe members recoiling at the initial attempts to point out character flaws and incongruencies in another members behavior or words? Your undoubtedly in a beginning or early stage of the group. Often time feedback is the cause for conflict and contention in a transitional stage of the group. Members who took what they perceived as criticism and stuck in in the junk drawer in an early stage are ready to make a case for themselves now. This isn't bad and it need not be scary, it's what Dr. Yalom calls grist for the mill. That is, all content, even conflict, has potential to create a new interpersonal experience for the members. Soon, as groups survive these transitional conflicts, members start asking others for feedback. Jenny will ask Susan how she really perceives her when she talks about her ex-husband. People at work stopped listening months ago. Am I really that annoying? Susan might reciprocate by pausing to hear what James has to say when she says she wants a better relationship with her son but doesn't know how. Maybe the fact that he's closer to her son's age can help her. Maybe James is revealing something about himself now and not just giving advice. Maybe what he is revealing is changing her.	Slide #11 & #12
Acceptance of self: Can anyone relate to the statement, "If they really knew me, they would reject me"? If James was making that statement to himself early in the group, he probably wouldn't have shared with Susan. This factor of group work can be difficult to interpret. Is James quiet because he doesn't like people? Is he quiet because he thinks the other members are old and stuck in	Slide #13, #14, and #15

their ways? Or, is he quiet because he is unable to accept himself? (Slide) Many recovery programs are geared toward helping individuals accept themselves. The introductions for AA or Celebrate Recovery are designed to allow others into our story. But, introducing ourselves as an alcoholic in the first session of a process therapy group may be too risky. We tend to start out with fear of and expectation of rejection. A leader of a new group might hear something like we heard in the content section and recognize that discussing the game and the weather is due to a rejection of self by some in the group. What are some things (and remember, these questions are for discussion, there are no concrete right and wrong answers to them) that a group member might come in thinking they *should* change but don't know how to change? Many new group members don't even know how to answer this question. They simply come in knowing they aren't like anyone else and don't want to reveal that. (Slide) One good way to build self-acceptance is with self-awareness. Like looking at ourselves through a pair of VR glasses, self-awareness helps us tap into what our bodies are telling us and what we are feeling. Close your eyes for a second (don't fall asleep on me) and rather than focus on your breathing or pushing thoughts and emotions away, become aware of what you are feeling in this moment. (Slide) As a group progresses, members hear from other members how they are seen. When June says to Jimmy, "When you look at me like that, I feel 10 years old, and I don't like it." It may be hard to hear, but Jimmy can say he does see her as 10 years old, but it's because she reminds him of his sister at that age and he misses her. June can become aware that she is likeable and lovable and not always seen as bad or rejected. She can then see herself as others are able to and accept the parts of her that may be gross or painful to her. Maybe Jimmy can then help her appreciate that younger part of her that was rejected by a father or a friend. As a leader, we will begin to see these characteristics as group progresses. We begin to see how the stages of a group are important as to the intervention we use or how much encouragement we give to working in the here-and-now and interpersonal work, or how much we allow trust building. You can see with self-acceptance that group members would have good reasons to stay in content and timeframes that allow them to stay hidden. Maybe you could validate June's tough statement to Jimmy and validate that part of her that needs healing. "June, great way to let Jimmy know what you were feeling. How was it to hear that you remind him of his sister just now?" The power of group factors is in the place and space they are working in this moment with this content, everything has potential for work. I bet some of you have experienced these phenomena before you even recognized what was happening. I know I did.

Openness to others: Think for a minute about a group you have been a part of (a team sport, or a class project), think about how your view of others has changed from the formation of that group to the last time you met (or maybe you still meet). ~~I'll ask you a question about that group in a second.~~ Just like a spectrum of openness to closedness (is that a word? It is now) to oneself, there is a spectrum of the same to others in a group. When you first joined that group I asked you to recall, how open were you to others ideas, feelings, and reactions? ~~Someone talk about that.~~ It's difficult isn't it, to allow others to affect us. The plain truth is that we do affect one another. In the car on the road, in the line at the grocery store, trying to relax on the beach on vacation, and in a therapy group, we affect one another. There is no escaping that human beings react to other human beings. The question is, how do we react? A stranger in the grocery store may elicit a head nod and glancing eye contact, but a member of a group who has just told us about a loss that deeply affects them and that they need help healing from elicits empathy and compassion. As empathy begins to grow for others and trust is formed by here-and-now interpersonal work, members begin to let others in. Moving from a protection of being known for who they really are to a longing to be known by others in the group. As the leader watching this transpire you will see growth in members as they literally ask, "how do you see me?" They will ask, "is it okay if I show you this part of me?" They will say to others, "I can accept that part of you. I can see who you are and stay in the room with you and hear your story, you are not too much for me." Whatever language they use to convey that, they are working together for healing of wounds that happened in relationship as they become more open to how others affect them. Because of this, the transitional stages are once again prime ground for conflict and controversy. We don't move from hidden to seen by kindness and affection alone. Remember that group I've been asking you to reflect on? Who in that group did you start out not too fond of? (don't answer, that's for later today maybe) I recall a friend my daughter had in High School. When they first met in Jr. High, they were repelled by each other. But, as they fought it out on the basketball court, they formed a friendship. Mostly over competition with others. They started feeling like sisters protecting the other from outsiders, "I can say that about her but no one else can!" type of stuff. This care produced some acceptance of the flaws and idiosyncrasies the other had. This acceptance produced some willingness to join with the others ideas and emotions. This is what happens in group therapy when the transition stages are less than tranquil. We use this time to build trust and inclusion and help our members develop interpersonally.

Slide #16

Acceptance of others: One of my favorite things in the world is to watch our one-year-old granddaughter Emelia (we call her meme) reach out to my wife for snuggles. One might think that the feeling in my heart and the tears in my eyes are of jealousy. “Why won’t she do that with me?” But I checked in with myself last weekend and they are not. I am actually extremely happy for my wife. I know that there is not much else in this world that makes her as happy as Meme reaching out to her, jumping into her arms, and burying her head in her shoulder! My emotions are there because I know how my wife is affected. You don’t have to have a husband or wife or mom or dad to experience this phenomenon. This value of others can come in built relationships as deeply as natural relationships (this, by the way, is a huge factor in group therapy. The interpersonal work that transpires in the working stage is transformative to member’s trained beliefs about others as much as about themselves). However, as the group begins, this phenomenon is missing or, at best, illusive. When members first step into that group, they are skeptical of how others see them and how they can be authentic. Members in the beginning stage might verbally shutdown transparency in others (maybe not as pointed as, hey, how ‘bout those chiefs?” but very close to it. Something like, “Whoa, TMI there Betty!”). Remember that group you were a part of we’ve been talking about. Earlier we asked how you went from being closed to knowing or being known to valuing that kinship. Now, similar to the content of the overall discussion we introduced early today, I wonder how the language of your group changed from the first time you met to the last time. Anyone want to unmute and give us some insight on that? How might a leader ask a member to share more authentically with a group? So, similar to those experiences, we will see that therapy groups will begin to, not just *allow* deeper intimacy, transparency, and authenticity in members, but will ask for it. They may call out inauthenticity and ask members to share in the moment about themselves rather than others. One important recognition and tool here is the difference between honor and honesty. When individuals are afraid to dishonor someone in a group (or maybe even a part of themselves), they will use careful, compassionate language. It may sound something like, “I mean I get it. That part of me is still hurt by you, but I don’t blame you for what you said.” And, while compassion is good, we can deflect more authentic parts of ourselves with it. A more authentic comment may sound like “I am still hurt by what you said last week, and I would like you to consider an apology, can we talk about that?” As this member helps encourage authenticity and doing work in the group for others, we can help them hold honor and honesty at the same time.

Slide #17

Language, timeframe, emotions, reactions, interactions, and transparency all serve as bark and leaves to us as we interpret and detect the stages of group.	
The leader and co-leader: one final note here before I hand it back to Dr. Ford. Whenever my dad is making me something I have specifically asked for like a desk or shelf for my office. He knows I have a specific look in mind (or better my wife has a specific look in mind). Rather than trying to explain that look and him trying to decipher the kind of wood I want it made from, we go to the specialty wood store together. We look through stack and stack of lumber as he says, naw, that's maple...won't look good. No...that's ash, it'll be too red. He asks me what I see, and I ask him what he sees. We collaborate on the perfect species for the present project. We make notes about what the guy has online so we can refer to them when we get there. And we step back after we've picked out a board and reflect on what it will make. As a leader, your co-leader is your best asset when it comes to figuring out where you are in the group. Collaborate, take good notes, and reflect on your own experience in the group. As you do these things, you will learn to identify your stages.	Slide #18